Notes on the Thesis Process

Reed College Linguistics Department
Fall 2025 - Spring 2026

The senior thesis is your opportunity to develop and defend an original research project in consultation with a thesis adviser and other faculty. In a thesis, the author poses a question on a particular topic and attempts to answer that question, supporting that answer with relevant data, analysis, and argumentation. The question and its answer constitute the "thesis of the thesis", while the data, analysis, and argumentation constitute the body of the thesis.

Because the final thesis is a bound document, organized into chapters with a title page and table of contents, seniors are often tempted to think they're writing a book—a highly daunting prospect! In fact, the thesis is a *much* more modest project. A good rule of thumb is that a thesis should have the same scope and level of detail as a medium-sized (say, 30-60 page) journal article. You might want to consult some journal articles in areas related to the topic of your thesis in order to get some idea of what this entails. And remember, the thesis template will make your page count go up considerably compared to your previous papers.

The thesis grade is based on the **final document**, the **thesis process**, and the **oral exam**:

(1) The document

Document margins, as well as the layout for the title page, table of contents, and other frontmatter, must follow college formatting guidelines. As such, we ask that you use one of the **thesis templates** provided by CUS for Word or LaTeX. *Write directly into the template,* rather than rushing to copy-paste everything from another document into the template before your deadlines, as the formatting will likely suffer.

How the body of the thesis is formatted is up to you and your adviser, and can vary somewhat with the choice of topic (e.g., a syntax thesis may not be formatted in the same way as a sociophonetics thesis). Chapters are usually divided into labeled and numbered sections. Numbering follows the 'outline' conventions commonly used in academic writing—e.g., the subsections of chapter 1 would be numbered 1.1, 1.2, 1.3, and so on. If section 1.1 has subsections, they will be numbered 1.1.1, 1.1.2, 1.1.3, and so on. If a section contains subsections, there must be at least two of them (for instance, if section 1.1 contains a subsection 1.1.1, it must also contain a subsection 1.1.2; if there's no need for a 1.1.2, then section 1.1 shouldn't be divided into subsections at all).

When it comes to figures, tables, trees, example sentences, etc., we suggest you follow the formatting guidelines of your favorite linguistics journal. (Many journals make their style guides available on the web.) The same goes for formatting your bibliography: unless your adviser specifies otherwise, you are free to follow the conventions used by any prominent linguistics journal, so long as you are consistent.

For further questions about formatting, consult your adviser. We also recommend that you look at the advice in chapters 3–5 of *Surviving Linguistics: A Guide for Graduate Students*, by Monica Macaulay. A copy of these chapters has been emailed to you. We have also sent a handout by Lynne Murphy entitled *Stylistic Choices that Degrade Writing*, which includes additional advice on proper writing style, structuring your argument, intended audience, etc.

A note on citation

In linguistics we use in-text citations rather than footnotes. The in-text citation consists of the author's last name and year of publication (e.g., Chomsky 1985); the author's full name and the title of their work generally do not appear in the text. There is no punctuation between the author's name and the year, just a space. When a direct quote is made, the in-text citation

must include page numbers (page numbers may also be included if you are citing something from a specific part of your source, even if no direct quotation is made). There are two main ways of including page numbers in the citation:

For a single page:	(Chomsky 1985, p. 23)	(Chomsky 1985: 23)
For a page range:	(Chomsky 1985, pp. 23–25)	(Chomsky 1985: 23–25)

You can use either style as long as you are consistent. Another thing to note: the author's last name goes *outside* the parentheses when it's a proper part of the sentence containing the citation, and *inside* the parentheses when it isn't. In the latter case the citation normally goes at the end of the sentence containing the idea being cited, although this is not a hard and fast rule. When the citation appears at the end of the sentence, it precedes the final period:

> "Chomsky (1985) claims that language first evolved in penguins."
> "Scientists claim that language first evolved in penguins (Chomsky 1985)."
> "Scientists (e.g., Chomsky 1985) claim that language first evolved in penguins."

Remember that citations should appear in the text *whenever* you draw from a source. Even very general statements should be supported with citations, as in the example below. Notice that when multiple citations appear together, they are typically separated by semicolons.

> "The language and gender literature tends to focus primarily on white, American females (Smith 1950; Lakoff 1972; Eckert 1999; Bucholtz 2010)."

You should also consistently cite a text as you make reference to it:

> "The extraction of F1/F2 formant values was first used by Mill (1950) in charting the phonology of British English. The use of F3, however, was unreliable in that study (p. 376)."

(2) The thesis process

In addition to the document itself, you will be graded on the thesis process—e.g., whether you come to thesis meetings prepared, do suggested reading assignments, submit drafts on time, etc. Normally you will meet with your adviser every week for up to an hour. It is up to you and your adviser to determine how you will spend your meetings, and what sort of preparation will be expected. Your adviser may also ask that they meet with you and their other advisees in a group meeting or "lab". Once per semester you will meet instead with your first reader.

*For students beginning their thesis in **fall 2025**, the following dates must be kept in mind:*

October 1, 2025 (5:00pm)
First Wednesday in October
Your formal **thesis proposal** is due. You must email a copy of your proposal to your adviser and our FAC (faculty administrative coordinator) Adam Aristo (aadam@reed.edu) **before 5pm**.

The thesis proposal normally consists of 2–3 pages of text plus an **annotated bibliography** of sources. The proposal needs to be more than just a brief summary of your thesis topic. Treat your proposal document as a 'proto-introduction' to your thesis. Specify the (preliminary) thesis of your thesis as clearly and concisely as you can, preferably in a sentence or two. Include information about the theoretical context within which your thesis is situated, as well as the methodologies you will use in your research. Below we have included a handout, *Writing a (Good/Great) Thesis Proposal* at the end of this document, which offers more detailed recommendations on how to structure your proposal.

Your thesis proposal must also include a brief statement summarizing your anticipated **research funding** needs. If you do not anticipate needing any money to complete your thesis research, please say as much. If you do anticipate asking for research funds, briefly explain how much money you think you will need and what you will need it for. (See section (4) below for information about funding sources.)

November 17-21, 2025

Four weeks before the first chapter deadline

This is the fall "Meet with your first reader" week. Instead of meeting with your adviser during this week, you will meet with your first reader. **It is your responsibility to schedule this meeting** in advance. During the meeting, you should plan to describe your thesis project to your first reader (including the thesis of your thesis and your proposed methods of data collection and analysis). Do not send your first reader anything to read; instead, plan to have a conversation during your meeting time.

December 18, 2025 (5:00pm)

Last day (Thursday) of final exams

Your **first chapter**, along with a revised and expanded (non-annotated) bibliography, must be submitted to your adviser and first reader. Your adviser will give you written comments on your first chapter, usually by the beginning of spring semester. Your first reader will give you oral or written feedback when you meet with them in the spring.

Note that this is not necessarily *the* first chapter of your thesis, although it is likely to include a lot of background material, such as a critical review of the previous literature on your topic. Almost inevitably, material from your first chapter will end up in different places in the final draft. However, it must be *a* chapter—that is, it must read like a chapter, with a beginning, middle, and end (i.e., an introductory section, body, and conclusion). It may help to think of the first chapter as comparable in length and organization to a final term paper in a regular course. There are no hard and fast page number requirements, since thesis documents can be of widely varying length depending on the project. However, if you aim to submit 10-15 pages you will probably be in good shape. The exact length and scope of your first chapter is something to discuss in advance with your adviser.

Then it's **Winter Break**!

February 9-13, 2026

Third week of classes

This is the spring "Meet with your first reader" week. As in the fall, you should schedule a meeting with your first reader in place of your regular meeting with your thesis adviser. During this meeting, you should expect to receive feedback from your first reader on your first chapter, and discuss your plans for completing the thesis project in the spring.

Around now, start thinking about your second and outside readers.

March 20, 2026 (5:00pm)

Six weeks before the last day of classes

The **complete rough draft** of your thesis is due. Please email a copy of your rough draft to your advisor and first reader **before 5pm**. You may want to check with your advisor and first reader about their preferences for the format of the document (some prefer PDF, some Word, etc.). Your adviser will give you detailed written comments on your draft as quickly as possible. Your first reader will also give you feedback about two weeks after this date. This feedback may be written or verbal, and you may or may not meet in person with your first reader. Regardless of

the form of feedback, you should acknowledge it by sending an email or describing in person to your first reader how you decided to incorporate their feedback.

Both of those adjectives, "complete" and "rough", should be taken seriously! The draft needs to be *complete* in the sense that there can be no gaps or missing sections. In addition, the draft must be properly formatted, with a title page, table of contents, and full bibliography conforming to the thesis template guidelines. In short, it must *look like* a finished thesis. However, it is not expected to be polished: after the deadline you will revise, reorganize, and expand what you've written, so concentrate on content, making sure that all of the elements of your analysis and argument are present.

IMPORTANT: *Be sure to proofread your draft thoroughly before submitting it. Then get your thesis buddy (an official title) to proofread it. If your adviser has to spend time on typos and formatting mistakes, that will significantly lengthen the turnaround time!*

Then it's **Spring Break**!

***April 10, 2026* [subject to change]**
Approximately three weeks before the last day of classes
You will present your thesis project in our **thesis showcase**, a sort of "posterless poster session", in which all thesis students will stand at high bistro tables while the Linguistics faculty, staff, junior students, and others wander around and ask about what you did and what you found during your thesis process. With light refreshments and the big deadlines behind you, this is meant to be a low-stakes way to talk about your research to audiences of different backgrounds and interests, which can help prepare you for your oral.

May 1, 2026 (3:00pm)
Last day of classes
https://vireo.reed.edu/
The **final draft** of your thesis is due. This is the version of your thesis which your committee will read and which your oral exam will be based upon. After submitting this version, you will not be allowed to make any substantive changes to the document except at the insistence of your committee.

Well before 3pm, you must send your final draft as a pdf to your thesis adviser. Your adviser will check it over (give them time for this!) and reply with an email letting you know it is approved for submission. You will then submit both the final draft (PDF) and adviser approval email (PDF) to the Registrar through their online thesis submission form (link above).

Once you hear back from the Registrar that your submission is complete, distribute copies to the members of your orals board. Many faculty are happy with a PDF copy sent over email, but check each member's preferences. If some want a hard copy, provide one to them.

Then it's **Renn Fayre**!

May 4-10, 2026
Reading week
Oral exams are held. This will be scheduled by our FAC. Your adviser will give you further suggestions on how to prepare when the time comes.

May 15, 2026 (12:00 noon)
Friday after exams

Submit a PDF of your finalized thesis electronically to the library. The finished thesis is fundamentally identical to the final draft distributed for the oral, unless there are typos or other minor errors which need to be corrected.

(3) The oral exam

The final component of your thesis grade is the oral exam. The oral exam (or "orals") is a 90-minute session in which you discuss the results of your thesis project with your adviser and the other members of your **orals committee**, composed of four members:

Adviser	Your adviser is a member of the Linguistics faculty, assigned by the department. Your adviser is responsible for meeting with you weekly to discuss your thesis, helping you with literature and research questions, and providing you with most of the oral and written feedback. Your adviser reads all drafts of your thesis, and gives you written comments on your first chapter and your complete rough draft. Your adviser also chairs the oral exam and assigns you your final grade, in consultation with the other members of the department and your orals committee.
First reader	Your first reader is another member of the Linguistics faculty, assigned by the department after you submit your formal proposal in October. Your first reader will receive copies of your thesis proposal, first chapter and complete rough draft, and give you feedback on them. You will meet with your first reader at least once a semester during Meet With Your First Reader Weeks, but you are encouraged to meet with them more often to get feedback on your project as appropriate.
Second reader	The second reader is chosen by the student. The second reader may be another member of the Linguistics faculty, or somebody outside the department (sometimes, but not necessarily, from the student's Allied Field). The second reader will only read the final draft of the thesis.
Outside reader	The outside reader is also chosen by the student. The outside reader *must* be from outside the PRPL Division—i.e., not a member of the Philosophy, Religion, Psychology, or Linguistics departments. The outside reader only reads the final draft of the thesis. (Note that the outside reader can be a non-teaching member of the faculty, including the president, the registrar, the head of the Sports Center, the head librarian, and the Vice President for Student Life, among many others.)

Since you are required to select *two* of the four members of your orals committee, you should begin thinking early about who you'd like to invite. Your second reader and outside reader do not need to know anything about your thesis topic; in fact, it often makes for a more interesting orals if they don't. It's more important that you invite people who you feel comfortable talking to and with whom you would like to share your research.

Be aware that faculty are usually unwilling to commit to being on your orals committee until after the orals in their own department/division have been scheduled. Most departments and divisions schedule their orals around the mid-semester break. Nevertheless, you should plan to approach potential board members early in your final semester so that they know you're interested in asking them to be on your committee.

(4) Conducting Thesis Research

Institutional Review Board. http://www.reed.edu/irb/

If you plan to use data generated by live human beings (a technical term!) you are required to submit an application explaining your research to Reed's Institutional Review Board (IRB). While many if not most kinds of linguistics research projects done at Reed are considered "exempt from review", even these projects require that some paperwork be reviewed by the IRB. Research requiring IRB approval includes ethnographic or interview-style fieldwork, collecting survey data, conducting experiments, or using recordings found on the internet. The IRB is a committee of faculty and staff tasked with ensuring that research subjects are treated ethically and humanely, and that their rights are respected. Instructions, contact information, and links for downloading forms can be found at the above address.

You can submit a human subjects approval form at any time, but plan to do so as early in the fall semester as possible. It will normally take 2 to 3 weeks for the IRB to review a proposal using expedited review (linguistics proposals that are not "exempt from review" normally count as "expedited review"), plus additional time to revise and resubmit your application for final approval. This means that if you plan on conducting research that requires IRB approval, you'll want to start working on an application as soon as you can .

(5) Thesis Funding

Linguistics Department. The Linguistics Department budget includes a small fund to support student research, which we distribute on an equitable basis among seniors requesting funding. In order to receive these funds, you will need to provide a brief description of your funding needs as part of your official thesis proposal. (If you don't anticipate needing funds for your project, please note this in your thesis proposal so that we can provide additional money to those who do need funds.)

Reed's approach to funding is to use disbursement; i.e. you must pay out of pocket, document your expense, then submit a receipt and be reimbursed. You can submit receipts directly to our FAC, Adam Aristo (aadam@reed.edu), who will process the disbursement. Also, if you are not able to pay out of pocket, you can also contact Adam or your thesis adviser and they will help you work this out. .

Initiative Grants
www.reed.edu/beyond-reed/fellowships-awards/sponsored/initiative.html
If you anticipate needing more than department funding for your project—perhaps because you will need to travel to a research site, or you need specialized equipment or software to carry out an experiment—you will need to apply to the Undergraduate Research Committee (URC) for an **Initiative Grant**.

The Reed Initiative Grant is a competitive grant which provides thesis students with small amounts of money to fund their research. This money can be used to pay for research-related equipment or supplies (which then become property of the college), or audio-visual costs not provided by other Reed facilities, among other things. If you're contemplating a project that will require more than a modest sum of research funds, you will need to apply for an Initiative Grant. Awards are based on the merits of your project and the availability of funds. If your thesis project involves working with human subjects, you must submit a completed **human subjects approval** form to the Institutional Review Board (IRB) *prior* to submitting your initiative grant application.

There are normally three deadlines to apply for an Initiative Grant (the last of which is targeted to those on the spring-fall thesis schedule). **Note** that the first fall deadline is very early - you'll need to decide on the scope of your research needs ASAP in order to apply. Check the link above for deadlines as they are not yet determined.

In the Initiative Grant application, indicate that you have already received the maximum amount offered by our department. If the URC is unable to meet your additional

funding needs, you should get back in touch with the department: depending on our budget, we may be able to offer additional funding to students above our limit on an as-needed basis.

Be sure to keep receipts from any research expenditures, since you will need to include these receipts with your disbursement form in order to be reimbursed!

(6) Online resources

www.reed.edu/linguistics/LoL

Lab of Linguistics (LoL). The LoL (Eliot 101D) is a space where students can conduct research and analysis. The lab houses a soundproof booth, laptops, and all sorts of equipment for collecting phonetic measurements, as well as a variety of recording devices which students can check out for use in data collection. For sociolinguistic interviews or to just work in a quiet space, we have a couch and chairs as well.

Our **lab manager Wren Arbor** and **lab assistants Rowan Horowitz, Rives Scherer, and Ezra Scheuermann** will hold weekly office hours, and are generally likely to be around in the LoL to drop in and chat. Please email the LoL team (laboflinguistics@reed.edu) and check the LoL webpage for checkout policies, office hours, and a list of equipment.

libguides.reed.edu/linguistics

The Library's research guide for linguists. Includes a list of linguistics reference books in the Reed College Library, as well as links to online journal articles, abstracts, and other research materials. For additional help with Library research, you should contact the linguistics library liaison, **Ann Matsushima Chiu** (chiua@reed.edu).

A note on books: Most of the sources you will need for your thesis can be obtained either from the Reed Library, or via Summit or ILL. The Department will also consider requests from thesis students to add materials to our permanent collection. If there is a book or other resource which you anticipate using extensively for your thesis which is only available through Summit/ILL, please talk to your adviser about ordering a copy for the Library.

www.reed.edu/writing/thesis.html

Thesis resources from the Writing Center. Includes links to information and advice on researching and writing a thesis, formatting your document, avoiding plagiarism, etc. Also includes links to thesis templates, CUS services, the Senior Handbook, and other useful sites.

(7) Advice from a thesis adviser: Tips on making the most of your thesis experience

(a) *Ownership*. Never forget that this is *your* thesis project! Your adviser's job is to support and guide you through the process, but the motivation and initiative come from you. Be prepared to have suggestions about what to talk about during thesis meetings, about readings you've come across that you'd like your adviser to read too, about how you work and how you think you and your adviser can work together. At the end of the day, this work is your own.

At the same time, there is a process component to your thesis grade, which means part of your job is to work well with your adviser throughout the year, finding a balance between your own ownership and direction, and your adviser's role as instructor. You'll probably notice this balance shift over time: In the first few months, your adviser will provide more structure as you design your project, write your thesis proposal, and develop an annotated bibliography. Later your adviser will take on more of a supporting role (as copyeditor, sounding board, cheerleader, and taskmaster), and expect you to lead the charge in completing your project.

(b) *Keep your calendar in mind, and work backwards*. There are some major deadlines during this process. It can help to know how many weeks you have until your next deadline, and to keep an outline of your plan to reach that deadline. For instance, if you have 10 weeks until a draft deadline and still need to finish your lit review/background chapter, analyze your data, write a results chapter, and write a conclusion, you might allocate a certain amount of time to each broad task. This can help ensure that you don't spend four weeks on the lit review when you really needed two of those weeks to work on your data. You get the idea.

(c) *Give yourself time and space to work.* Set aside time every week that's just devoted to working on your thesis. It's all too easy to get sidetracked by the more immediate demands and deadlines of your other courses. To avoid procrastination, it's useful to schedule weekly times during which you give yourself permission to think about nothing but thesis. To avoid getting bored, plan a mix of activities (writing, revising, reading articles, transcribing, etc.).

Some students find it useful to carry a small notebook with them (or to have a note-taking app on their phone) so they can jot down thesis ideas or plans while on the go. Referring to your notes can help you get started the next time you sit down to work.

(d) *Write every week*. Getting your thoughts down on paper consistently, and sending that writing to your adviser, can be a great way to keep your juices flowing. You'll be surprised at how the writing builds up over time, so when it comes time to write a chapter, you'll realize you already have most of it in rough form.

A few people find they need to focus on one topic at a time in order to get any writing done. Many people, however, find it useful to work on more than one part of the thesis at once. This is one way to keep from getting discouraged by writer's block: if one section isn't going well, you can just work on another section.

(e) *See the writing tutors*. Academic Support offers drop-in writing times in Vollum CC126 (https://www.reed.edu/academic_support/tutor-schedule/index.html). You may be a great writer already, or you may struggle with your exposition. Either way, we strongly recommend showing your work to the writing tutors. If nothing else, you get an extra pair of eyes pointing out everything from typos to places where your explanation is unclear. The writing tutors are great because they can spot gaps in your argumentation that you and your adviser might miss!

(f) *Respect your adviser's time (and your own time)*. You have a weekly hour slot to meet with your adviser. You should know what it is you want to accomplish during that time. At times, you'll have your head down writing or analyzing your data. During these times you and your adviser might decide to skip a week, or just have a quick check-in meeting, rather than meeting for an entire hour.[1] At other times you'll want (oral) feedback from your adviser on something you've written, in which case your adviser will need time to read through it. A good rule of thumb: If you're sending less than 5 pages, you need to do so at least *48 hours in advance, or 72 hours over a weekend*, if you expect substantive feedback. If you're sending more than 5 pages, your adviser may need up to a week. So plan ahead!

(g) *Frontload*. You will be amazed at how quickly time flies in the fall semester. The reality of the thesis process is that you'll end up doing the bulk of your writing after winter break, when you have only 10 weeks or so left before your draft is due. Whatever you can do to push yourself in the fall, do it! This is particularly true if you're working with quantitative data or research design, or doing elicitation or other fieldwork. The more you can get done sooner, the happier both you and your adviser will be come spring.

[1] It should go without saying that the decision to cancel a thesis meeting requires the consent of your adviser. As in any class, unexcused absences negatively affect the process portion of your thesis grade.

Writing a (Good/Great) Thesis Proposal
Steve Hibbard, Fall 2009
(*edited and updated by Matt Pearson*)

Form and Function: In general, a thesis proposal in the Linguistics Department should be two or three pages long and include the following information:

(1) Thesis statement. This should be a simple paragraph detailing the idea behind your thesis. You should be able to sum up your thesis in a single sentence. Consider this good practice; after all, you'll have to describe your thesis, in very brief, clearly understandable terms, to all sorts of people throughout the year. The rest of the paragraph should further clarify, and expand on, your thesis statement. Your thesis statement should catch the attention of the reader. It should be compelling. Have you, for example, discovered a paradox—whether theoretical, empirical, or some combination of the two—that your project might help resolve?

(2) Theoretical framework(s). This section should be considerably longer than the first—though, still, one or two good paragraphs should suffice. It should describe, in some detail, the theoretical framework(s) within which your thesis, as a whole, is embedded. What perspectives, discourses, and/or specific scholars will inform your work? Why are they useful to you—how, specifically, will they help you? In more general terms, what is the state of the relevant literature? What has already been written about your chosen topic? And how will your proposed project contribute to existing debates?

(3) Methodology. The most important purpose of this section is to explain, as concretely as possible, how it is that you will go about demonstrating what you set out to demonstrate. What exactly will you do in order to provide evidence for the hypothesis and/or arguments at the heart of your thesis? What kinds of resources will you use? How and where will you find them? If you plan to write a more-or-less strictly theoretical thesis (a "library thesis", as Matt likes to say), describe how you will use the library, online resources, etc., to engage the relevant scholarship. If you plan to collect original data (whether ethnographic, field-linguistic consultant-based, or what have you), describe just how and where you will collect your data.

(4) Funding needs. If your project will require research funds—e.g., for travel to a fieldwork site, purchasing necessary equipment/software or supplies, paying language consultants, etc.—include a short paragraph explaining what you will need the funds for, and approximately how much you will need. You don't need to provide a detailed budget, but be as specific as you can based on your current understanding of your project. This information will help us determine how to allocate the department's research funds (see section (5) above). If you do not anticipate needing any funds for your thesis research, please indicate that as well.

(5) Annotated bibliography. In this section you should present a list of the books, journal articles, web pages, etc., most relevant to your thesis. Sources should include, most centrally, key texts in the theoretical framework(s) presented in your Theory section—perhaps also texts directly relevant to your empirical work as presented in the Methodology section. Form and style are not as important as content and depth (though, of course, you should work out the appropriate style with your adviser). The bibliography should be as detailed as you can make it, and should reflect a month's worth of meetings and discussions with your adviser, other Linguistics faculty, and anyone else who might be able to help you. Be careful to include *all* relevant work, especially work that is conventionally accepted as canonical in the areas central to your project, whether or not you agree with its conclusions or approach.

FAQ: The "Snake Fight" Portion of Your Thesis Defense

by Luke Burns
www.mcsweeneys.net

Q: *Do I have to kill the snake?*

A: University guidelines state that you must "defeat" the snake. There are many ways to accomplish this. Lots of students choose to wrestle the snake. Some construct decoys and elaborate traps to confuse and then ensnare the snake. One student brought a flute and played a song to lull the snake to sleep. Then he threw the snake out a window.

Q: *Does everyone fight the same snake?*

A: No. You will fight one of the many snakes that are kept on campus by the facilities department.

Q: *Are the snakes big?*

A: We have lots of different snakes. The quality of your work determines which snake you will fight. The better your thesis is, the smaller the snake will be.

Q: *Does my thesis adviser pick the snake?*

A: No. Your adviser just tells the guy who picks the snakes how good your thesis was.

Q: *What does it mean if I get a small snake that is also very strong?*

A: Snake-picking is not an exact science. The size of the snake is the main factor. The snake may be very strong, or it may be very weak. It may be of Asian, African, or South American origin. It may constrict its victims and then swallow them whole, or it may use venom to blind and/or paralyze its prey. You shouldn't read too much into these other characteristics. Although if you get a poisonous snake, it often means that there was a problem with the formatting of your bibliography.

Q: *When & where do I fight the snake? Does the school have some kind of pit or arena for snake fights?*

A: You fight the snake in the room you have reserved for your defense. The fight generally starts after you have finished answering questions about your thesis. However, the snake will be lurking in the room the whole time and it can strike at any point. If the snake attacks prematurely it's obviously better to defeat it and get back to the rest of your defense as quickly as possible.

Q: *Would someone who wrote a bad thesis and defeated a large snake get the same grade as someone who wrote a good thesis and defeated a small snake?*

A: Yes.

Q: *So then couldn't you just fight a snake in lieu of actually writing a thesis?*

A: Technically, yes. But in that case the snake would be very big. Very big, indeed.

Q: *Could the snake kill me?*

A: That almost never happens. But if you're worried, just make sure that you write a good thesis.

Q: *Why do I have to do this?*

A: Snake fighting is one of the great traditions of higher education. It may seem somewhat antiquated and silly, like the robes we wear at graduation, but fighting a snake is an important part of the history and culture of every reputable university. Almost everyone with an advanced degree has gone through this process. Notable figures such as John Foster Dulles, Philip Roth, and Doris Kearns Goodwin (to name but a few) have all had to defeat at least one snake in single combat.

Q: *This whole snake thing is just a metaphor, right?*

A: I assure you, the snakes are very real.